I'd turned them down. This time, I told them they were out of their minds. I said the bulk of conservatives in America were Republicans and they wouldn't desert the party for a third party. If I was ever going to make progress in accomplishing the things I believed in, it would have to be within the Republican Party. They wouldn't listen to me, and so I walked out on them.

Some of those conservative diehards have never forgiven me for it. (Later, I learned some of them subsequently held a secret meeting at which they almost convinced Alexander Haig to run against me.)

If I decided to run in 1980, I knew I'd have to deal with two issues in particular: I'd have to show the Easterners who were suspicious of *any* Westerner, but especially Californians, I wasn't an extremist and I'd have to deal with the issue of my age.

If I won in 1980, I would turn seventy shortly after Inauguration Day and become the oldest president in history. (Actually, that birthday would be the thirty-first anniversary of my thirty-ninth birthday. When I turned sixty-five, I'd begun joking, like Jack Benny, that subsequent birthdays marked the anniversary of my thirty-ninth birthday.)

The truth is, I felt thirty-nine or younger. I didn't feel any different or any older than the way I'd *always* felt. But I realized it was inevitable that the press would focus attention on my age.

I'd never taken naps or dyed my hair, but that hadn't stopped reporters from suggesting I did. (The rumor about dyeing my hair, incidentally, started when I was governor. My barber told me that after I left his shop people sometimes came in and asked if they could pick up a strand or two of my hair to see if the roots were gray. I'm the first person I know of who was actually happy when gray hair started growing on his head.)